Chapter 66 — Server-Sent Events & Long Polling

> **Part VIII — Real-Time & Connectivity** · Complexity: **Standard** (≥25 interview questions)
>
> **Prerequisites:** Ch 63 (WebSocket), Ch 1 (networking/OkHttp), Ch 2 (retries/backoff), Ch 49 (FCM), Ch 3 (SSOT), Ch 44 (lifecycle). Pairs with Ch 64 (chat), Ch 32 (sync), Ch 68 (network state).
>
> **Reference surface in StreamCart:** the **one-way, server→client** real-time cases — an order-status feed, a live scoreboard/price ticker, notifications stream — where a full WebSocket (Ch 63) is more than needed, and where **SSE** or **long polling** are the simpler, HTTP-native fit.

66.1 Problem Definition and Real-World Context

Not every real-time feature needs the full bidirectional WebSocket (Ch 63). Many are **one-way**: the server pushes updates, the client only listens (order status, live scores, a price ticker, a notifications feed). For these, two HTTP-native mechanisms are often **simpler and more robust** than a WebSocket: **Server-Sent Events (SSE)** — a long-lived HTTP response streaming `text/event-stream` events, with **built-in auto-reconnect and event ids** — and **long polling** — the client makes a request the server holds open until there's data (or a timeout), then immediately re-requests. Picking the wrong transport (WebSocket where SSE suffices, or naive short polling where nothing scales) costs complexity, battery, or server load.

Concretely, teams hit:

- **Over-using WebSocket.** A WebSocket is bidirectional, stateful, and needs its own heartbeat/reconnect/backpressure machinery (Ch 63). For **server→client-only** feeds, **SSE** gives you streaming + auto-reconnect + resume (`Last-Event-ID`) over plain HTTP with far less code.
- **Naive short polling.** Polling every few seconds is laggy, wasteful, and scales terribly. **Long polling** (hold the request open) gives near-real-time with simple infra; **short polling** is a fallback only for infrequent, non-urgent data.
- **Reconnection & resume.** A dropped stream must reconnect (backoff, Ch 2) and **resume from the last event** so nothing is missed. SSE standardizes this (`id:` + `Last-Event- ID` header); long polling uses a **cursor**; both must reconcile via the SSOT/REST (Ch 3/32).
- **Lifecycle & background (Ch 44/47).** Like WebSocket, these are **foreground** transports — hold them only while active; **FCM** (Ch 49) handles background.
- **Choosing among WS / SSE / long poll / FCM.** The decision depends on directionality, frequency, infra, and app state — getting it right is the core skill.

The architecture: for **one-way server→client** streams, prefer **SSE** (streaming HTTP + built-in reconnect + `Last-Event-ID` resume) and use **long polling** when SSE isn't available or events are infrequent; manage them like any real-time transport — **reconnect with backoff** (Ch 2), **resume from the last event id/cursor** (Ch 32), **feed a `Flow` that updates the SSOT idempotently** (Ch 3/15), **scope to the active lifecycle** and hand off to **FCM** (Ch 49) in the background (Ch 44); and **choose WS vs SSE vs long poll vs FCM** by directionality/frequency/app-state. This chapter is about **the simpler one-way real-time transports and when to use each**.

Three practical use cases

1. **Order-status feed (StreamCart).** SSE stream of order updates while the order screen is open — auto-reconnects, resumes via `Last-Event-ID`, updates the SSOT; FCM when backgrounded (Ch 49).
2. **Live scoreboard / price ticker.** SSE one-way stream of frequent updates, coalesced for the UI (Ch 63 backpressure) — simpler than a WebSocket for a read-only ticker.
3. **Long-poll fallback.** Where SSE/WebSocket are blocked (restrictive proxy) or events are rare, long polling with a cursor delivers near-real-time with basic HTTP infra.

Why this is architectural

Transport choice (WS vs SSE vs long poll vs FCM) is a **cross-cutting real-time decision** spanning directionality, frequency, infra, battery, and app state (Ch 63/49/44). SSE and long polling are the **simpler one-way options**; knowing when each beats a WebSocket — and reusing the same reconnect/resume/SSOT discipline (Ch 2/32/3) — is essential real-time design.

66.2 Requirements Engineering

Functional requirements

ID	Requirement
F1	Receive one-way server→client updates in near real time (SSE or long polling).
F2	Reconnect with backoff; resume from last event id / cursor (no missed events) (Ch 2/32).
F3	Feed updates into the SSOT idempotently; reconcile via REST (Ch 3/15/32).
F4	Scope to active lifecycle; hand off to FCM in background (Ch 44/49).
F5	Choose the right transport (WS / SSE / long poll / FCM) per need.
F6	Authenticated + secure stream (Ch 19/23); untrusted events.

Non-functional requirements

Attribute	Policy
Simplicity	SSE/long-poll over HTTP; less machinery than WebSocket for one-way.
Reliability	Reconnect + resume; missed events self-heal via SSOT/REST.
Battery	Foreground only; FCM for background (Ch 47/49).
Latency	Near-real-time (SSE streaming / long-poll hold).
Robustness	Works through proxies better than WS in some networks.

Scope

- **In scope:** SSE (`text/event-stream` , event ids, `Last-Event-ID` resume, auto- reconnect), long polling (hold-open request + cursor + immediate re-request), short polling (fallback), reconnect/backoff (Ch 2), resume/cursor (Ch 32), events → idempotent SSOT (Ch 3/15), lifecycle scoping + FCM handoff (Ch 44/49), transport selection (WS/SSE/ long poll/FCM), auth/security (Ch 19/23).
- **Out of scope:** WebSocket internals (Ch 63), FCM internals (Ch 49), sync algorithm (Ch 32), backoff theory (Ch 2), networking stack (Ch 1), chat (Ch 64).

Assumptions & constraints

- OkHttp (Ch 1) for SSE (streaming response / `okhttp-sse`) and long polling; Kotlin coroutines/Flow; Room SSOT (Ch 3); FCM (Ch 49). `minSdk 24` . These are **foreground, one-way** transports; delivery is best-effort (reconcile via SSOT/REST); events are untrusted.

66.3 System Design Fundamentals

- **Server-Sent Events (SSE).** A single long-lived **HTTP GET** whose response is `Content-Type: text/event-stream` ; the server streams **events** (`data:` lines, optional `event:` type and `id:`) and keeps the connection open. Key built-ins:
    - **One-way** (server → client only) — simpler than WebSocket's full duplex.
    - **Auto-reconnect:** the SSE client reconnects automatically on drop (with a server- suggestable `retry:` interval).
    - **Resume via `Last-Event-ID` :** the client remembers the last event `id:` and sends it as the `Last-Event-ID` header on reconnect; the server **replays from there** — missed events self-heal (standardized catch-up, Ch 32).
    - **HTTP-native:** works over normal HTTP/1.1 and HTTP/2, through most proxies/CDNs, with existing auth (Ch 19) — often **more robust** than WebSocket in restrictive networks.
- **Long polling.** The client sends a request; the **server holds it open** until there's data (or a timeout), then responds; the client **immediately re-requests** (with an updated **cursor**). Near-real-time with **basic HTTP infra** (no streaming/WebSocket support needed). Costs: a request per event batch, careful timeout/cursor handling. **Short polling** (fixed interval, respond immediately even if empty) is the laggy, wasteful fallback — only for **infrequent, non-urgent** data.
- **The decision matrix (the core skill):**

Need	Transport
Bidirectional, low-latency, foreground (chat, auctions)	**WebSocket** (Ch 63)
One-way server→client stream, foreground (status, ticker, feed)	**SSE**
One-way, SSE/WS unavailable or events rare, basic infra	**Long polling**
Infrequent, non-urgent	**Short polling** (simplest)
Background/killed wake-ups	**FCM** (Ch 49)
Default to **SSE for one-way**; **WebSocket only when you need to send too**; **FCM for	
background**.	

- **Same real-time discipline as WebSocket (Ch 63).** SSE/long-poll are managed like any real-time transport:
  - **Reconnect with backoff + jitter** (Ch 2) — SSE does basic reconnect; add jittered backoff for storms.
  - **Resume** — SSE via `Last-Event-ID`; long poll via a **cursor** in each request.
  - **Events → `Flow` → idempotent SSOT** (Ch 3/15) — dedup by event id, order by sequence; the UI observes the SSOT (UDF, Ch 6).
  - **SSOT/REST is truth** (Ch 32) — the stream is a **fast path**; missed events are caught up via resume or a REST delta, so drops self-heal.
- **Lifecycle & background (Ch 44/47/49).** SSE/long-poll are **foreground** transports (a held-open HTTP connection drains battery and is killed by Doze, Ch 47). **Connect on foreground, disconnect on background** (Ch 44); hand off to **FCM** (Ch 49) for background events; reconnect + catch up on return.
- **Backpressure for high-rate SSE** (Ch 63): coalesce/sample frequent events (ticker, scoreboard) so the UI isn't flooded.
- **Auth & security (Ch 19/23).** SSE is a normal authed HTTPS GET (bearer, cookies) over **TLS + pinning** (Ch 23) — reuses the REST auth stack (an advantage over WebSocket's custom handshake). Long polling likewise. Treat every event as **untrusted** (validate/ allowlist, Ch 23/52); the server authorizes **which stream** you may subscribe to.

Core insight: **for one-way server→client real-time, prefer SSE — a long-lived HTTP `text/event-stream` with built-in auto-reconnect and `Last-Event-ID` resume that reuses the REST auth stack and traverses proxies well — and use long polling (hold-open request + cursor) when SSE/WebSocket are unavailable or events are rare (short polling only for infrequent data); manage them with the same discipline as WebSocket (jittered-backoff reconnect, resume via event-id/cursor, events→idempotent SSOT with SSOT/REST as truth so drops self-heal, Ch 2/32/3/15), scope them to the foreground lifecycle and hand off to FCM in the background (Ch 44/49); and choose WS vs SSE vs long-poll vs FCM by directionality, frequency, infra, and app state — reserving WebSocket for when the client must also send.**

66.4 High-Level Architecture


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Components & ownership

- **Transport selector** picks WS/SSE/long-poll/short-poll/FCM by direction/frequency/ state.
- **SSE / long-poll** stream events, reconnect with backoff, resume via `Last-Event-ID` / cursor.
- **Events → idempotent SSOT merge** (dedup/order); the UI observes the SSOT.
- **SSOT/REST** is truth; **FCM** handles background; **lifecycle** scopes it.

Direction: need → transport choice → managed stream (reconnect/resume) → idempotent SSOT → UI; foreground-scoped with FCM background.

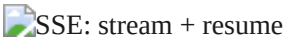
66.5 Detailed Component Design

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Component	Responsibility
`SseClient`	stream `text/event-stream`; `Last-Event-ID` resume; backoff reconnect
`LongPollClient`	hold-open request + cursor + immediate re-request
`RealtimeFeed`	expose events as Flow → idempotent SSOT merge (Ch 3/15)
`TransportSelector`	choose WS/SSE/long-poll/short-poll/FCM (decision matrix)

66.6 End-to-End Data Flow

SSE: stream + resume

 SSE: stream + resume

Long polling

 Long polling

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66.7 Complete Kotlin Implementation

Package: `com.streamcart.feed`.

66.7.1 SSE client (OkHttp), resume via Last-Event-ID + backoff

```
@Singleton
class SseClient @Inject constructor(
    private val okHttp: OkHttpClient,            // TLS + pinning + auth (Ch 1/19/23)
    private val cursorStore: LastEventIdStore,   // persist last id (Ch 3/32)
) {
    fun stream(url: String): Flow<SseEvent> = callbackFlow {
        var attempt = 0
        fun connect() {
            val req = Request.Builder().url(url)
                .header("Accept", "text/event-stream")
                .apply { cursorStore.last()?.let { header("Last-Event-ID", it) } }   // resume
(Ch 32)
                .build()
            val es = EventSources.createFactory(okHttp).newEventSource(req, object :
EventSourceListener() {
                override fun onOpen(es: EventSource, r: Response) { attempt = 0 }
                override fun onEvent(es: EventSource, id: String?, type: String?, data: String)
{
                    id?.let { cursorStore.save(it) }                                //
remember last id
                    trySend(SseEvent(id, type, data))
                }
                override fun onFailure(es: EventSource, t: Throwable?, r: Response?) {
                    // jittered backoff reconnect (Ch 2) -> resume from Last-Event-ID
                    launch { delay(backoff(attempt++)); connect() }
                }
            })
            awaitClose { es.cancel() }
        }
        connect()
    }
    private fun backoff(a: Int) = minOf(30_000L, 500L * (1L shl a.coerceAtMost(6))) +
Random.nextLong(500)  // (Ch 2)
}
```

66.7.2 Long-poll client (hold-open + cursor + re-request)

```
@Singleton
class LongPollClient @Inject constructor(private val api: FeedApi, private val cursorStore:
CursorStore) {
    fun stream(channel: String): Flow<Event> = flow {
        while (currentCoroutineContext().isActive) {
            val resp = runCatching { api.longPoll(channel, cursor = cursorStore.get(channel),
timeoutSec = 30) }  // server holds open
                .getOrElse { delay(backoff()); continue }                // error -> backoff
(Ch 2), retry
            resp.events.forEach { emit(it); cursorStore.set(channel, it.seq) }   // advance
cursor
            // loop immediately re-requests with the new cursor (near-real-time)
        }
    }.flowOn(Dispatchers.IO)
}
```

66.7.3 Feed: events → idempotent SSOT merge (Ch 3/15); REST reconciles

```
@Singleton
class OrderFeed @Inject constructor(
    private val sse: SseClient, private val dao: OrderDao,    // SSOT (Ch 3)
    private val api: OrderApi, private val scope: CoroutineScope,
) {
    fun start() = scope.launch {
        sse.stream("https://api.streamcart.com/orders/stream").collect { ev ->
            val update = parseOrder(ev.data) ?: return@collect     // untrusted (Ch 23)
            dao.upsertIfNewer(update)                              // idempotent: dedup by
id/seq (Ch 15)
        }
    }
    /** On (re)connect/open: REST catch-up = truth (Ch 32) — drops self-heal. */
    suspend fun catchUp() = dao.upsertAll(api.ordersSince(dao.maxSeq()))
}
// UI observes dao.observeOrders() (Ch 6). SSE is a fast path; SSOT/REST is truth.
```

66.7.4 Transport selection (the decision)

```
object TransportSelector {
    fun choose(need: RealtimeNeed): Transport = when {
        need.bidirectional && need.foreground -> Transport.WebSocket   // must send too (Ch 63)
        need.oneWay && need.foreground && need.sseSupported -> Transport.Sse          // DEFAULT
one-way
        need.oneWay && need.foreground -> Transport.LongPoll           // SSE/WS unavailable
        need.infrequent -> Transport.ShortPoll
        need.background -> Transport.Fcm                               // Ch 49
        else -> Transport.Sse
    }
}
```

66.7.5 Lifecycle scoping + FCM handoff (Ch 44/49)

```
// Foreground-only (held-open HTTP drains battery + Doze-killed, Ch 47). FCM for background (Ch
49).
class FeedLifecycleBinder @Inject constructor(private val feed: OrderFeed) :
DefaultLifecycleObserver {
    private var job: Job? = null
    override fun onStart(owner: LifecycleOwner) { job = feed.start() }   // connect SSE
    override fun onStop(owner: LifecycleOwner) { job?.cancel() }         // disconnect -> FCM
handles bg
}
```

66.7.6 Module structure

```
:core:feed   SseClient, LongPollClient, OrderFeed, TransportSelector, cursor/LastEventId stores
# OkHttp/SSE -> Ch 1; backoff -> Ch 2; SSOT -> Ch 3; catch-up -> Ch 32; FCM -> Ch 49; lifecycle
-> Ch 44.
```

66.8 Concurrency and Race Conditions

Scenario	Risk	Handling
Reconnect loses events	gaps	`Last-Event-ID`/cursor resume (Ch 32)
Duplicate on resume replay	dup state	idempotent SSOT upsert (dedup by id, Ch 15)
Reconnect storm	server load	jittered backoff (Ch 2)
Long-poll overlapping requests	double work	single in-flight per channel; advance cursor
High-rate SSE floods UI	jank	coalesce/sample (Ch 63)
Held connection in background	battery/Doze	foreground-only; disconnect (Ch 44/47)
Stale cursor after reinstall	re-replay	server tolerates; idempotent merge dedups

- **Resume + idempotency mirror WebSocket (Ch 63):** SSE's `Last-Event-ID` (or the long-poll cursor) replays missed events on reconnect, and the **idempotent SSOT merge** (dedup by id, Ch 15) makes the inevitable **replayed duplicates** harmless — so drops self-heal without corruption.
- **Single in-flight long-poll per channel:** the loop must not launch overlapping requests; one request at a time, advancing the cursor from each response.
- **Jittered backoff** prevents reconnect storms just as for WebSocket (Ch 2/63).

66.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

Failure	Detection	Response	Outcome
Stream drops	onFailure	backoff reconnect + resume (Ch 2/32)	heals
Missed events	gap in id/seq	`Last-Event-ID`/cursor replay + REST catch-up	self-heals
Duplicates on replay	repeated id	idempotent SSOT (Ch 15)	single
WebSocket blocked by proxy	connect fail	SSE/long-poll (HTTP-native) fallback	works
High-rate flood	jank	coalesce/sample (Ch 63)	smooth
Battery drain	held connection bg	foreground-only + FCM (Ch 44/49)	battery ok
Short-poll too laggy	user report	switch to SSE/long-poll	near-real-time


66.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

> **SSE and long polling reuse the same real-time principles as WebSocket (Ch 63) — reconnect, resume, idempotent-SSOT, SSOT/REST-as-truth, foreground-scope + FCM — but over plain HTTP and one-way, so they're simpler and more proxy-robust.** The real skill is **choosing the right transport**: SSE for one-way streams, WebSocket only when the client must send, long-poll as the HTTP fallback, FCM for background.

66.10 Scaling the Implementation

- **Level 1.** SSE for a one-way feed → idempotent SSOT; auto-reconnect.
- **Level 2.** `Last-Event-ID`/cursor resume + jittered backoff (Ch 2/32); REST catch-up; lifecycle scoping + FCM background (Ch 44/49).
- **Level 3 — production.** Transport selection (WS/SSE/long-poll/FCM); backpressure for high-rate (Ch 63); long-poll fallback where SSE/WS blocked; auth/pinning (Ch 19/23).
- **Level 4 — large.** Multiplexed SSE channels; adaptive transport (fall back WS→SSE→ long-poll); per-feed coalescing; connection-quality metrics.
- **Level 5 — enterprise.** Real-time transport governance + fallback matrix, QoS SLOs, server-side streaming scale (SSE fan-out), multi-region, HTTP/2 multiplexing tuning.

Avoid overengineering: for a read-only feed, **SSE + idempotent SSOT + FCM background** is the whole story — don't reach for a WebSocket. Don't short-poll frequent data; don't hold connections in the background.

66.11 Alternative Approaches and Trade-offs

Dimension	Option A	Option B	When
One-way stream	**SSE**	WebSocket (Ch 63)	SSE (simpler, HTTP-native, auto-reconnect/resume); WS only if bidirectional
No SSE/WS infra	Long polling	short polling	Long poll (near-real-time); short poll only infrequent
Resume	`Last-Event-ID` (SSE) / cursor (long-poll)	none	Always resume (Ch 32)
Reconnect	Jittered backoff (Ch 2)	immediate/fixed	Jittered (avoid storms)
Truth	SSOT/REST (fast path)	the stream	SSOT/REST (self-heal)
Background	FCM (Ch 49)	hold connection	FCM (battery/Doze, Ch 47)
Proxy-restrictive nets	SSE/long-poll (HTTP)	WebSocket	SSE/long-poll (traverse proxies better)

SSE vs WebSocket (Ch 63): a WebSocket is **bidirectional and stateful**, needing custom handshake, heartbeat, and reconnect machinery. **SSE** is **one-way** over plain HTTP with **built-in auto-reconnect and `Last-Event-ID` resume**, reuses the **REST auth stack** (Ch 19), and traverses proxies/CDNs more reliably. For **server→client-only** feeds (status, ticker, notifications), SSE is simpler and often more robust; use a **WebSocket only when the client must also send** (chat, auctions). Many apps use SSE for feeds and WS only where duplex is genuinely needed.

Long polling vs short polling vs SSE: short polling (fixed interval) is laggy and wasteful — fine only for **infrequent, non-urgent** data. **Long polling** (server holds the request open) gives **near-real-time** with basic HTTP infra and is the fallback when SSE/WS aren't available or events are rare. **SSE** is better than both for a true stream (one connection, many events, standardized resume). Prefer SSE; long-poll as fallback; short-poll only for rare updates.

Stream-as-truth vs SSOT/REST-as-truth: as with WebSocket (Ch 63), treating the SSE/ long-poll stream as authoritative makes a dropped event a permanent loss. Treating it as a **fast path** over an **authoritative SSOT/REST**

(Ch 32) — with resume + idempotent merge — makes it self-healing. Same principle across all real-time transports.

66.12 Security Considerations

- **Authed HTTPS + pinning (Ch 19/23):** SSE/long-poll are normal authenticated HTTPS requests over **TLS + certificate pinning** (Ch 23) — they reuse the REST auth stack (bearer/cookies), an advantage over WebSocket's custom handshake. Never plain HTTP.
- **Stream authorization (Ch 23):** the server authorizes **which feed/channel** you may subscribe to (your orders, a stream you're watching) — a client can't request arbitrary streams.
- **Events are untrusted (Ch 23/52):** validate/allowlist event types and schema; don't act on an event implying privilege without server authorization; sanitize content; beware injection.
- **Per-account isolation (Ch 42):** feeds scoped to the active account; on logout/switch, disconnect + scope.
- **`Last-Event-ID`/cursor are not secrets** but shouldn't leak another user's position; they're validated server-side against the authed user.
- **No sensitive data/PII in event logs** (Ch 28).
- Client vs backend: the **server** authenticates, authorizes the stream, assigns event ids/cursors, and is the truth (REST catch-up); the **client** manages reconnect/resume, validates untrusted events, and reconciles into the SSOT.

66.13 Performance and Resource Optimization

- **SSE over WebSocket for one-way** — less machinery, HTTP/2 multiplexing, proxy-friendly.
- **Foreground-only** (Ch 44) — don't hold SSE/long-poll in the background (battery/Doze, Ch 47); FCM for background (Ch 49).
- **Jittered backoff** (Ch 2) — avoid reconnect storms + radio churn.
- **Coalesce/sample high-rate** streams (Ch 63) — ticker/scoreboard.
- **Resume, don't refetch all** — `Last-Event-ID`/cursor replays only missed events.
- **Long-poll timeout tuning** — balance latency vs request overhead; single in-flight.
- **HTTP/2** — multiplex multiple SSE streams over one connection.
- **Profiling:** stream uptime, reconnect rate, event latency, battery/radio, catch-up volume, request count (long-poll).

66.14 Testing Strategy

SSE/long-poll test with `MockWebServer` (stream responses / held requests); resume + merge in isolation.

```
class SseResumeTest {
    @Test fun `sends Last-Event-ID on reconnect and dedups replay`() = runTest {
        // MockWebServer: stream events 1-3 then drop; assert reconnect carries Last-Event-ID=3,
        // server replays 3-5, SSOT has 1-5 once (idempotent, Ch 15)
    }
}

class LongPollTest {
    @Test fun `advances cursor and re-requests`() = runTest {
        // held response returns seq 101-102 -> next request carries cursor=102
    }
    @Test fun `backs off on error then retries`() = runTest { /* error -> delay -> retry (Ch 2)
*/ }
}

class TransportSelectorTest {
    @Test fun `one-way foreground picks SSE`() =
        assertEquals(Transport.Sse, TransportSelector.choose(RealtimeNeed(oneWay = true,
foreground = true, sseSupported = true)))
    @Test fun `bidirectional picks WebSocket`() = assertEquals(Transport.WebSocket, /* ... */ )
    @Test fun `background picks FCM`() = assertEquals(Transport.Fcm, /* ... */ )
}
```

What to test: SSE resume (`Last-Event-ID`) + idempotent dedup of replay; long-poll cursor advance + backoff; transport selection matrix; REST catch-up heals gaps; lifecycle connect/disconnect (no background hold); untrusted-event rejection. `MockWebServer` for streaming/held responses.

66.15 Production Observability

- **Metrics:** stream **uptime / reconnect rate / reconnect latency**; event **delivery latency**; catch-up/replay volume + gap frequency; long-poll request rate; duplicate- merge rate (deduped); battery/radio attributed; transport mix (SSE/long-poll/WS/FCM).
- **Logs:** `feed{transport, state, reconnects, lastEventId}` — no event content/PII (Ch 28).
- **Debugging:** missed events → resume not sent / cursor bug (Ch 32); duplicates → merge not idempotent (Ch 15); storms → non-jittered backoff; WS-blocked network → fall back to SSE/long-poll; battery → held connection in background (Ch 44); laggy → short-poll where long-poll/SSE needed.
- **Alerting:** reconnect-rate/latency spike; SSE failure spike (server/proxy); transport- fallback surge (infra issue).
- **Dashboards:** stream health (uptime/reconnect/latency) by transport; delivery funnel.

66.16 System Design Interview Preparation

> ≥25 questions.

Fundamentals

1. *SSE?* A long-lived HTTP `text/event-stream`; server streams events one-way.
2. *SSE built-ins?* Auto-reconnect + `Last-Event-ID` resume + HTTP-native.
3. *Long polling?* Client request the server holds open until data/timeout, then re-request.
4. *Short polling?* Fixed-interval polling — laggy/wasteful; infrequent data only.
5. *Direction of SSE?* One-way (server→client).

Choosing

6. *SSE vs WebSocket (Ch 63)?* One-way HTTP+resume vs bidirectional stateful.
7. *When WebSocket?* Client must also send (chat/auctions).
8. *When long poll?* SSE/WS unavailable or events rare; basic infra.
9. *When FCM?* Background (Ch 49).
10. *Default for a read-only feed?* SSE.

Reliability

11. *Resume (SSE)?* `Last-Event-ID` header → server replays from there.
12. *Resume (long-poll)?* Cursor in each request.
13. *Reconnect?* Jittered backoff (Ch 2).
14. *Duplicates on replay?* Idempotent SSOT merge (Ch 15).
15. *Truth?* SSOT/REST (Ch 32); stream is a fast path.
16. *Missed events?* Resume + REST catch-up self-heal.

Lifecycle/efficiency

17. *Foreground only?* Yes — held connection drains battery, Doze-killed (Ch 47).
18. *Background?* FCM handoff (Ch 49).
19. *High-rate?* Coalesce/sample (Ch 63).
20. *Proxy-restrictive nets?* SSE/long-poll traverse better than WS.

Security

21. *Auth?* Normal authed HTTPS + pinning (Ch 19/23); reuses REST stack.
22. *Stream authz?* Server authorizes which feed (Ch 23).
23. *Events trust?* Untrusted — validate (Ch 52).

Testing/Production

24. *Test SSE?* `MockWebServer` stream + resume/dedup.
25. *Test selection?* Matrix (one-way→SSE, bidir→WS, bg→FCM).
26. *WS blocked in prod?* Fall back to SSE/long-poll.

Design-change challenges

1. **One-way order-status feed.** SSE + idempotent SSOT + `Last-Event-ID` resume; FCM background.
2. **WebSocket blocked by a corporate proxy.** SSE or long-poll (HTTP-native).
3. **Rare updates, simple backend.** Long polling with a cursor (or short poll if very rare).
4. **Live ticker floods the UI.** SSE + coalesce/sample (Ch 63).
5. **Feed misses events after a drop.** `Last-Event-ID`/cursor resume + REST catch-up (Ch 32).

Mock walkthrough (abridged)

Clarify (one-way or bidirectional, frequency, infra, app state?) → transport matrix (SSE for one-way, WS for bidirectional, long-poll fallback, FCM background) → manage like real-time (reconnect+backoff, resume via Last-Event-ID/cursor, events→idempotent SSOT, SSOT/REST truth, Ch 2/32/3/15) → foreground scope + FCM (Ch 44/49) → backpressure for high-rate → auth/pinning + untrusted events (Ch 19/23) → observability.

66.17 Practical Exercises

1. **Beginner.** Consume an SSE order-status feed with OkHttp, updating the SSOT; render from the SSOT. *Eval:* streams; UI updates.
2. **Intermediate.** Add `Last-Event-ID` resume + jittered-backoff reconnect so drops heal and replays dedup idempotently. *Eval:* no gaps/dupes.
3. **Advanced.** Implement a long-poll fallback (hold-open + cursor) and a `TransportSelector` choosing WS/SSE/long-poll/FCM. *Eval:* correct choice; near-real-time long-poll.
4. **Production debugging.** Fix missed events (resume not sent) and a reconnect storm (no jitter). *Eval:* resumes; spread reconnects.
5. **System design challenge.** Scope the feed to foreground with FCM background, add coalescing for a high-rate ticker, and a stream-health dashboard. *Eval:* battery-sane; smooth; observable.

(Solutions withheld unless requested.)

66.18 Chapter Summary & Reference Sheet

Key decisions: for **one-way server→client** real-time, prefer **SSE** — a long-lived HTTP `text/event-stream` with **built-in auto-reconnect and `Last-Event-ID` resume** that **reuses the REST auth stack** (Ch 19) and **traverses proxies/CDNs** better than a WebSocket — and use **long polling** (server holds the request open + a cursor + immediate re-request) when SSE/WebSocket are unavailable or events are rare (**short polling** only for infrequent data); manage these with the **same discipline as WebSocket** (Ch 63) — **jittered-backoff reconnect** (Ch 2), **resume** via `Last-Event-ID`/cursor (Ch 32), **events → idempotent SSOT merge** (dedup by id, Ch 3/15) with **SSOT/REST as the truth** so drops self-heal, **foreground-scoped** with **FCM for background** (Ch 44/49) — and **choose the transport by directionality, frequency, infra, and app state** (SSE one-way, **WebSocket only when the client must also send**, long-poll fallback, FCM background); secure with **authed HTTPS + pinning + server stream authorization + untrusted-event validation** (Ch 19/23/52).

Concepts: SSE (`text/event-stream` , event ids, `Last-Event-ID` , auto-reconnect), long polling (hold-open + cursor), short polling, transport selection matrix, reconnect/backoff

- resume, events → idempotent SSOT, SSOT/REST truth, foreground scope + FCM, backpressure.

Common mistakes: using a WebSocket for a one-way feed (needless complexity); short- polling frequent data (laggy/wasteful); no resume (gaps); no idempotent merge (duplicates on replay); treating the stream as truth; holding SSE/long-poll in the background (battery/ Doze); plain HTTP / no stream authz; non-jittered reconnect (storms).

Checklist:

- [ ] pick transport by matrix (SSE one-way / WS bidirectional / long-poll fallback / FCM background)
- [ ] SSE with `Last-Event-ID` resume + auto-reconnect
- [ ] long-poll hold-open + cursor (single in-flight)
- [ ] jittered backoff (Ch 2)
- [ ] events → idempotent SSOT merge (Ch 3/15)
- [ ] SSOT/REST = truth; catch-up (Ch 32)
- [ ] foreground-scoped + FCM background (Ch 44/49)
- [ ] coalesce high-rate (Ch 63)
- [ ] authed HTTPS + pinning + stream authz + untrusted events (Ch 19/23/52)
- [ ] stream-health telemetry.

Key APIs: OkHttp `EventSources` / `EventSource` / `EventSourceListener` (`onEvent` / `onFailure`)

- `Accept: text/event-stream` + `Last-Event-ID` header, OkHttp long-poll (held GET + cursor), `callbackFlow` / `flow` (Ch 1), jittered backoff (Ch 2), Room idempotent upsert (Ch 3/15), REST catch-up (Ch 32), `ProcessLifecycleOwner` (Ch 44), FCM (Ch 49), `MockWebServer` (test).

References:

- Server-Sent Events (WHATWG/MDN): https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/API/Server-sent_events
- OkHttp SSE (okhttp-sse): https://square.github.io/okhttp/features/events/
- (composes) Ch 63 WebSocket, Ch 1 Networking, Ch 2 Retries/Backoff, Ch 49 FCM, Ch 32 Sync, Ch 3 SSOT, Ch 44 Lifecycle, Ch 68 Network State

Chapter review (Phase 4)

- **Completeness:** all 18 sections; architecture/class/sequence/flow/failure diagrams; SSE client (Last-Event-ID + backoff) + long-poll + feed merge + selector + lifecycle code; concurrency (resume+idempotency, single in-flight, jitter); failure (reuse-WS- principles + choose-transport); 5 levels; SSE-vs-WS, long-vs-short-poll, stream-vs-truth trade-offs; security (authed HTTPS, stream authz, untrusted); perf (SSE/foreground/ coalesce); MockWebServer + selector tests; observability (stream health); 26 Q&A + 5 challenges. ✅
- **Expand later:** WebSocket (Ch 63), FCM (Ch 49), sync (Ch 32), network state (Ch 68).
- **Interview coverage:** exceeds ≥25 bar.